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2 Timothy

2 Timothy 1:1–18

Paul and Timothy were very close friends. Paul loved Timothy like a son.

Paul prayed for Timothy every day and longed to see him again. Timothy had learnt about faith in God from his mother and grandmother.

He had received a gift of the Spirit when Paul placed hands on him. Paul wanted Timothy to use his gift faithfully to serve the church. He could do this by teaching the truth about Jesus.

Paul had taught Timothy how to teach the truth. The Holy Spirit would give him the power and love he needed to do it. The truth of the good news is that Christ has broken the power of death.

Upon Jesus' return to earth he will judge all things on judgement day. He gives eternal life to those who trust in him.

Paul had been put in prison for spreading that message. Many people who had been Paul's friends were ashamed that he was in prison. They deserted him when he was treated badly. But God's Spirit gave Paul strength to face these troubles. The faith and friendship of believers like Onesiphorus and Timothy encouraged Paul.

2 Timothy 2:1–26

Paul made it clear that Timothy needed God's grace to follow Jesus faithfully. He also needed to work hard. The effort required was like the hard work done by soldiers, sports players and farmers.

Many people oppose the message about Jesus. Paul had been put in prison by people who wanted him to stop preaching it. Other people accept the message but argue about it. Fights about the faith lead people to stop believing what is true about Jesus. Paul mentioned two believers who had done that. He hoped that they would turn back to the truth.

Paul encouraged Timothy not to hold onto anger against people like that. Instead, he should continue to preach the truth gently. Timothy was a young man. Paul urged him to say no to evil things that tempt young people. Instead, he should do good works and be full of faith, love and peace.

Paul reminded Timothy of something important about God's grace. Even when believers fail to follow Jesus faithfully, Jesus will always be faithful to them.

2 Timothy 3:1–4:5

In the last days people will treat each other badly. They will act the opposite of how Jesus taught human beings to live. They will follow their own desires instead of being controlled by God's Spirit. They will teach lies about God. Certain people will try to trick others on purpose.

Timothy must stay away from people like that. Instead, he should follow Paul's example. Paul was full of faith and love. He was patient and didn't give up. He trusted in God to save him when he was treated badly. Timothy must also continue to be patient and careful as he taught about Jesus.

Paul called the good news about Jesus the Word. The message about Jesus is made clear in God's word. Paul explained that God had breathed life into all Scripture. Breathing life into something is also what God did when he created human beings in Genesis 2:7. Paul meant that the Bible is more than a collection of words that humans wrote. God's Spirit can use Scripture to teach believers and to heal wounds in their heart. Studying Scripture can train believers to do the good works God wants them to do.

Paul warned Timothy that he would be treated badly if he followed Jesus faithfully. People wouldn't want to hear the message of truth. But he must keep doing the work God had given him.

2 Timothy 4:6–22

Paul believed that he was near the end of his life. He was like a soldier who had obeyed his officer and fought well. He was like a runner who had obeyed the rules and won the race. These were ways that Paul described how he had followed Jesus faithfully.

So God would reward him with the crown like runners received after a race. The crown or prize was that he would live for ever with Jesus. Paul longed for when that would happen.

While Paul was still alive on earth, he was suffering in prison. Many of his companions had left him. Paul didn't have some of his important belongings. Through it all Paul was very aware of God's presence with him. Paul described this as Jesus standing at his side. That is how near Jesus felt to Paul.

Paul suffered in his body. But he knew that he was safe in the kingdom of God.